

From: **Dick Schottler** <birdshot2@comcast.net>
To: **Peter Gent** <gent@ucar.edu>
Subject: LUWA Report
Date: 25.10.2022 09:30:26 (+02:00)

RARE BIRD SIGHT RECORD

Species: LUCY'S WARBLER (*Oreothlypis luciae*)

Sex: male

Plumage: adult

Dates of observation: 17, 18 May 2016

Location: Wheatridge Greenbelt, Wheatridge, Jefferson County, CO

Lengths of observation: just a few seconds (< 10 sec.) on 17 May; abt. 30 sec. on May 18.

Times of observation: abt. 1430 on May 17; abt. 0735 on May 18

Other observers: None that I am aware of (unfortunately)

Weather & light conditions: overcast/gray, calm, temp in 40's on May 17; partly cloudy, calm, temp in 40's on May 18. Bird was seen only in shade on May 17; seen in shade and sunlight on May 18.

Optical equipment used: Brunton 8.5x binoculars

Distance from bird: est. 15 ft on May 17; from 15 to 40 ft. on May 18

Bird was not photographed.

Habitat in which bird was seen: Wooded greenbelt with large trees (cottonwoods) and understory of shrubs and bushes

Behavior: A very active bird, constantly flitting about. The only time I saw it relatively still was when it came in to investigate the "mobbing" recording on May 17 and it stood on a branch for a few seconds before flying out of sight. Bird stayed quite low - I don't think I ever saw it more than 8-10 feet above ground level even though tall trees were. present.

Description: A small (est. 4-4.5 in.) very plain nondescript light gray bird, paler gray below. No wing bars or other plumage features. Prominent dark eye on a plain gray face with no obvious eye ring. Thin dark sharp-pointed bill. Undertail coverts very pale gray - appeared almost white. Rusty reddish rump (seen both times) and crown patch (seen on May 18). Its "plainness" was what initially caught my eye (and confused me as to its ID).

Similar Species and how eliminated:

General comment: To my knowledge, the reddish crown and rump patches on an otherwise small, very plain pale gray bird are characteristics unique to Lucy's' Warbler, eliminating all species that it might be confused with.

Virginia's Warbler: Has prominent eye ring, yellow under tail coverts; yellow-green (not reddish) rump; has yellow on breast..

Yellow Warbler (female): Can be quite pale yellowish overall, but not gray; no reddish rump or crown patches

Bushtit: Has different overall shape and behavior, longer tail, no reddish rump or crown patches.

Bell's and Gray Vireos: Both have "vireo" bills and wing bars; neither has reddish crown and rump patches.

Prior experience with this and similar species:

Lucy's Warbler: I have limited experience with this species having seen small numbers in southeastern Arizona on several occasions. I have seen it once in Colorado - a singing male in Montezuma County (junction of Yellowjacket and Moccasin Canyons) in May 2004.

Virginia's Warbler: I have lots of experience with this species in Colorado, seeing it annually.

Yellow Warbler: Lots of experience, seeing many every year in Colorado

Bushtit: I have lots of experience with this species, seeing it regularly in my yard and elsewhere in Colorado.

Vireos: Have seen both in Colorado and elsewhere.

References used (none during initial observation):

1. Sibley, David A. The Sibley Guide to Birds
2. Dunn, Jon L. & Kimball L. Garrett. A Field Guide to Warblers of North America
3. Keller, Geoffrey A. Bird Songs of Southeastern Arizona and Sonora, Mexico

This report was made from notes made immediately after my observation on May 17 and about 2 hours after my observation on May 18.

Additional notes: On the afternoon of May 17, I was playing the Cornell "screech owl mobbing" recording when a small nondescript plain gray bird appeared on a branch just above my Ipod. My first thought was Bushtit, but it didn't "fit" (the overall shape and behavior were wrong). Then I thought it might be a Virginia's Warbler, but I ruled this out since there was no obvious eye ring and the undertail coverts were light gray (almost white), not yellow. When the bird flew off after a few seconds, I thought I saw a reddish area on the bird's rump. I do not recall hearing the bird vocalize. At this point I was confused about the ID - the idea of Lucy's Warbler never crossed my mind at the time. Just then a Hermit Thrush and Warbling Vireo came in to the recording, and I left the bird unidentified, but did jot down a few notes on what I had seen. On getting home I looked in my field guides, and Lucy's Warbler appeared to be a perfect match to what I had seen.. I decided I should try for the bird the next morning hoping to get a better look. I went back to the Greenbelt on the morning of May 18 to try again for the now "probable" Lucy's Warbler, arriving at the spot about 0730. Since the weather had cleared overnight, I really did not expect to refind it. I played a recording of Lucy's Warbler song, and the bird appeared almost instantly. I turned off the recording, hoping to minimally disturb the bird. This time I was able to get better looks at it in better light for a longer time, seeing the distinctive reddish rump and crown patches. The bird was very active and constantly moving, slowly getting a bit more distant as it appeared to be foraging for insects. I heard chip notes, but do not recall hearing the bird sing (but my hearing is not that great and I was concentrating on looking). Since I don't carry a camera, I decided I needed to try to get someone with a camera to "verify" the sighting so I called several birders I knew who take excellent photos. First call was to Glenn Walbek - he was in Limon,

but he did post a message on COBIRDS for me re a probable Lucy's Warbler in the Greenbelt. I next tried Norm Erthal and Mark Chavez, getting hold of both. Both arrived with their cameras within 20-30 minutes. We returned to the area where I had seen the bird, and I played the Lucy's Warbler recording fully expecting the bird to appear, but had no response. I also tried the "mobbing" recording, again with no luck. The three of us searched the surrounding area for the next hour or more without refinding the bird. Frustrating! Although I am confident of my ID, I was really hoping to get some "validation" by having other competent birders see, and with luck photograph, the bird. Further searching on the morning of May 19 failed to turn up any sign of the bird.

Date of report: May 30, 2016

Reporting observer: Dick Schottler

Address: 25 S. Indiana Place, Golden, CO 80401

Phone/Email: 303-278-8035/ birdschot2@comcast.net